

Australian Public Health Advisory # 2 – October 14, 2024

Issued by: Australian Government Department of Health and Aged Care

Location: Canberra, Australia

Evolving Respiratory Illness Situation in Queensland

The Australian Government Department of Health and Aged Care, in coordination with Queensland Health, is closely monitoring the ongoing respiratory illness investigations in Brisbane and now Townsville. As of October 14, there has been an increase in hospital admissions for acute respiratory illness, with several cases testing negative for routine respiratory pathogens.

While some of the recently identified cases have been confirmed as seasonal influenza infections, others remain under active investigation.

Key Developments:

- 25 hospital admissions in Brisbane Metro North hospitals since October 9.
- 1 new suspected case hospitalized in Townsville with a recent travel history from Brisbane. Contact tracing is underway.
- 7 of the previously suspected cases were positive for influenza and have been removed from the active investigation.
- Total confirmed deaths linked to the Kelvin Grove nursing home outbreak: 4.
- No confirmed link between new hospitalizations and previously recorded clusters.

Federal Government Response Measures:

- **Enhanced national surveillance** for severe respiratory illness through the Australian Sentinel Practices Research Network (ASPREN).
- **Expanded laboratory testing and genomic sequencing** to identify potential emerging pathogens.
- **Rapid contact tracing and case monitoring** in Brisbane and Townsville.
- **Increased coordination with the Australian Health Protection Principal Committee (AHPPC)** to assess potential national risks.
- **Federal notification to the World Health Organization (WHO) Western Pacific Regional Office (WPRO)** under International Health Regulations (IHR).

Risk Assessment:

- Current public health risk: Moderate (pending further investigation).
- Risk of widespread community transmission: No confirmed evidence at this time.
- International concern: No travel restrictions at this stage, but updates will follow pending ongoing surveillance.

Public Advisory & Recommendations:

- Individuals experiencing **severe respiratory symptoms** (e.g., difficulty breathing, persistent fever, severe cough) should **seek immediate medical care**.
- Older adults, immunocompromised individuals, and young children should **take extra precautions** due to potential increased severity.
- Travelers from **Brisbane to other regions**, including Townsville, should **self-monitor for symptoms** and report any illness to health authorities.
- Healthcare providers are **advised to be vigilant** in detecting and reporting unexplained respiratory cases **negative for common viral and bacterial panels**.

At this time, **there are no travel restrictions** but **all Australians are advised to remain informed** as new updates emerge. Further details will be provided as laboratory investigations continue.